

SUHAS GOPINATH, 21

Bangalore

COMPANY: Globals. Provides IT solutions for educational institutes, corporates.**HOW HE'LL SPEND HIS FIRST MILLION:** Invest in a farmhouse and keep lots of animals there**ADDICTED TO:** Chocolates. Keeps a fridge full in office.

"All my employees are older than me. To avoid any ego clashes, we keep a horizontal work structure."



had earned enough (Rs 70,000) to fund the server fees for the ensuing quarter. Today, their company, Directi, a web service provider, has been valued at \$300 million (Rs 1,173 crore) by RBC, their investment banker. "We figured if we had to do something really big, we'd have to focus on volume-based projects and not on individual customer-centric ones," asserts Divyank. Their other company, Skenzo, designs software that enables sites to monitor the traffic and monetise the hits for the online advertising industry. It will display 15 billion ads to over 200 million unique Internet users across the world this year.

The Turakhias have come a long way. Their dream project started operations in a small room in their chartered accountant father's office in Mumbai's Andheri area and now em-

ploys close to 400 people across 230 countries. They have traded the Santro they had bought in 1999 for a Mercedes C200 and Porsche Boxster S. Their sights are now set on the skies. They want a private jet. The good Gujarati boys (mention that and they squeal in unison "we don't want to be branded that") get little time to party—"we work till nearly 4 a.m. everyday"—but are into extreme adventure sports like hot air ballooning

Indian entrepreneurs is on the rise, teenage entrepreneurs are a rarity. "In the US, kids are enterprising right from their early days. They do summer jobs and part-time jobs. How many youngsters here do that?" asks Professor V. Chandrashekhar, executive director, Wadhwani Centre for Entrepreneurship Development at the Indian School of Business, Hyderabad. However, not all agree that entrepreneurs should start so young. "Success

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rate amongst teent entrepreneurs is very low. In today's hi-tech world, it is important to have some analytical skills and work experience under your belt," says Professor U.B. Desai, faculty adviser to the IIT Bombay entrepreneurship centre.

Interestingly, many young entrepreneurs feel that the school curriculum they were bred on has failed them. "It does not promote basic skill learning in a practical context," says Divyank. However, early entrepreneurship brings along un-

and shark cage diving.

That's some achievement you might say. You are right, given these bright sparks are making progress despite, and not because of, the system in India. It isn't smooth sailing for anyone who chooses to don the entrepreneur's hat in our country. Gopinath, who lives with his parents and elder brother, could not register his company in India as he was then under 18 years of age. He had to incorporate it in the US, with his partner Samuel, an adult American. While recognising that his age has proved a talking point, Samar admits that it is often a handicap. "I can't sign legal documents. I get my dad to sign for me," he shrugs. Gopinath admits he missed out on a \$0.5 million deal with a Singapore-based company as he was too young to sign the dotted line.

Even though the number of young

reasonable pressure, from parents and peers. Clearly there is admiration and interest. "One of my friends said, my mom's friend in India read about your product," says Samar, "and I was like wow! How do they already know?" But Badshah has another take: "My friends don't look at me any differently. The only difference between us is that, five days out of the week I have to juggle my schoolwork and business."

But do these gifted children burn out early due to pressure? "I think we need to remember that gifted children are children first and they need to have a normal childhood. Very often, these children are intellectually smarter (than peers), but are below average in social skills," reasons Lane. She may well have a point. It might make some ponder, but which parent wouldn't want his or her kid to get an early start? The trade-off is clearly a no-brainer. ■